interviews filmed in the GDR and weaved into FRG news reports to add impact and immediacy. ‘It’s not a happy combination, is it?’ Honecker once remarked. In another interview, he snapped: ‘You know, FRG mass media constantly publicises incorrect reports about the GDR. If we wanted to deny all of them, we would have very little time to deal with our proper work.’14

In the end, Der Spiegel’s ‘opposition manifesto’ story combined with other negative reporting denoted the expiry of many privileges enjoyed by the foreign press corps. Tired of the denigration of the GDR, the government introduced new controls in April 1979 seeking to prevent sidewalk interviews – the move was intended to discourage GDR citizens from giving statements to foreign journalists, as well as dissuading reporters from seeking them. At the same time, West German journalists who had been a persistent thorn in Honecker’s side became a particular target.15 Furthermore, Western correspondents seeking interviews were required to apply to the Ministry of Interior for permission and expected to announce trips outside East Berlin twenty-four hours in advance, stating the purpose of the journey.

It was no coincidence that this sudden crackdown came during the continuing economic malaise. One astute interpretation from the American embassy was that retail prices were set to rise, and criticism of government policy would be amplified by grumbling East Germans pouring their hearts out to Western TV. In fact, as predicted, a series of sharp price rises on consumer goods, textiles, furniture and car parts were introduced as higher quality items were presented at twice the price of the products they replaced.

Despite the credit crunch, Honecker managed to lavishly fund celebrations marking the 30th Anniversary of the GDR. American foreign correspondent John Dornberg witnessed the First Secretary exhort East Germans to ‘work harder, produce better quality goods, study more intensely, have more children, tighten their belts, waste less energy, and even brush their teeth more often – all in honour of our nation’s birthday’.

To mark the occasion on 5 October, columns of goose-stepping troops marched through East Berlin to open an orchestrated show of worker solidarity and national unity. Television viewers saw live coverage of